

Ryan M. Smith

PhD Candidate, Computer Science • University of British Columbia, InfoVis Lab
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EDUCATION

- University of British Columbia**, Vancouver, BC Sep 2022 – Aug 2027 (expected)
PhD Candidate, Computer Science • InfoVis Lab • Supervisor: Dr. Tamara Munzner
- New York University**, New York, NY Sep 2014 – May 2016
MA, Psychology • Focus: Cognitive & Social Psychology
- Marist College**, Poughkeepsie, NY Sep 2010 – May 2014
BA, Psychology • Dual minor in Communication & Business

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Text visualization; personal and medical data; visualizing vague and imprecise language; patient–clinician communication; visualization-as-input

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

- InfoVis Lab, University of British Columbia**, Vancouver, BC Sep 2022 – Present
Graduate Researcher • Supervisor: Dr. Tamara Munzner
- Designing and building patient-centric visualization systems (HealthTale, published at IEEE VIS 2026; SymptomTale) that transform unstructured patient narratives into structured timelines for clinical encounters.
 - Collaborating with industry partner Thrive Health to connect research prototypes to real clinical workflows.
- Visual Thinking Lab, Northwestern University**, Evanston, IL Feb 2020 – May 2022
Volunteer Research Assistant • PI: Dr. Steven Franconeri
- Designed, ran, and analyzed studies on visual perception of data using R and Excel.
 - Contributed to multiple studies on color saturation, graph size, shape rotation, and scatterplot area.
 - Prepared study stimuli, coding sheets, and analysis scripts.
- DePaul University Social Cognition Lab**, Chicago, IL Sep 2019 – May 2022
Volunteer Research Assistant • PI: Dr. Kimberly Quinn
- Contributed to manuscript development from existing lab data.
 - Conducted literature reviews and presented synthesized findings at lab meetings.

PUBLICATIONS AND PRESENTATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Journal & Conference Papers

- Smith, R.**, Chin, K. D., & Munzner, T. (2026). “HealthTale: A Patient-Centric Health Story Visualization Tool.” *IEEE Transactions on Visualization and Computer Graphics (Proc. IEEE VIS 2026)*, to appear. arXiv:2605.20207.
- Oddo, M. I. B., **Smith, R.**, Kobourov, S., & Munzner, T. (2026). “Visualization Tasks for Unlabeled Graphs.” *IEEE Transactions on Visualization and Computer Graphics*, 32(7), 5969–5983. doi:10.1109/TVCG.2026.3676348

Peer-Reviewed Workshop Papers

- Smith, R.** (2026). “User Study 47B: Interactive Dashboards After Answer-First Analytics.” In *VIS×SciFi Workshop, IEEE VIS 2026*.
- Smith, R.** (2025). “Position Paper: Potential Areas of Bias in Visualization-as-Input Systems.” In *Proc. Workshop on Envisioning a Research Agenda for Input Visualization, IEEE VIS 2025*.

Conference Presentations

- Smith, R.**, Chin, K. D., & Munzner, T. (May 2026). “HealthTale: A LLM-Assisted Health Story Visualization Tool.” BC AI Research-to-Adoption Summit.
- Smith, R.**, & Munzner, T. (May 2025). “How Do Patients Visualize Their Own Health Stories?” SeattleVis Day, Seattle, WA.
- Smith, R.**, Bellovary, A., & Quinn, K. (February 2021). “Sense of Place and Student Wellbeing: Preliminary Evidence for Impact of Liked but Not Disliked Spaces.” Society for Personality and Social Psychology Annual Convention, Virtual.

Smith, R., Krenzer, W., Quinn, K., & Gomez, P. (November 2020). "The Cheerleader Effect: Replication and Extension." Psychonomic Society Annual Meeting, Virtual.

GRANTS AND FUNDING

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| MITACS Accelerate Grant IT44143 | 2025 |
| Two-year, CAD \$90,000 grant for industry collaboration with Thrive Health. | |
| MITACS Accelerate Grant IT38408 | 2024 |
| One-year, CAD \$45,000 grant for industry collaboration with Thrive Health. | |

AWARDS, HONORS, & CERTIFICATIONS

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| IEEE VIS 2026 Doctoral Colloquium | 2026 |
| • Selected participant; presented thesis work to a panel of senior visualization researchers. | |
| Instructional Skills Workshops for Graduate Students | 2026 |
| • Completed the Instructional Skills Workshop (ISW), an internationally recognized, intensive 24-hour teaching certification focused on learner-centred pedagogy and instructional design | |
| UBC Faculty of Science Excellence in Service Award | 2025 |
| • Annual award given to two students in UBC's Faculty of Science for service and positive impact. | |
| • Recognized for advocating an embedded counselor within the Faculty of Science, enabling graduate students to access mental-health support without navigating the central university queue. | |

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

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| Lecturer · COGS 303, Research Methods in Cognitive Systems, UBC | Jan 2026 – May 2026 |
| • Designed and delivered a full undergraduate research methods course, consisting of 38 students, including development of syllabus, instructional materials, and assessment structure. | |
| • Implemented an active-learning, high-engagement classroom model emphasizing small-group, application-focused sessions and student-led inquiry | |
| Teaching Assistant · CPSC 447, Introduction to Visualization, UBC | Winter 1 2023, Winter 2 2025 |
| • Supported course design and grading for assignments, projects, and exams on data visualization. | |
| • Held regular office hours and Piazza discussions; provided detailed feedback on student projects. | |
| • Maintained course website and materials. | |
| Teaching Assistant · CPSC 103, Introduction to Systematic Program Design, UBC | Winter 2 2023 |
| • Graded assignments and tests; gave feedback focused on clean, efficient programming practices. | |
| • Ran course labs covering core programming concepts and provided technical support for student projects. | |
| Teaching Assistant · CPSC 100, Computational Thinking, UBC | Winter 1 2022 |
| • Led course labs introducing foundational computer-science concepts and problem solving. | |
| • Graded assignments and exams. | |

SERVICE AND LEADERSHIP

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| President · Computer Science Graduate Student Association, UBC | May 2026 – May 2027 |
| • Leading the CS GSA; representing CS graduate students to the department and university. | |
| Vice President · Computer Science Graduate Student Association, UBC | May 2024 – May 2025 |
| • Co-led CS GSA operations, events, and advocacy. | |
| Councillor · Graduate Student Society, Executive Oversight Committee, UBC | Apr 2024 – Present |
| • Elected councillor representing graduate students; serve on the Executive Oversight Committee. | |
| TA Union Steward · CUPE 2278, Computer Science Department, UBC | Feb 2024 – Present |
| • Department steward for the UBC teaching-assistant union; represent TAs on labor and workload issues. | |
| Reviewer · ACM CHI 2026 | 2025 |
| • Reviewed submissions for the ACM CHI 2026 conference. | |